

Arthritis and Weight Management in the UK

Every pound lost reduces 4 pounds of knee pressure. UK guide to weight management with arthritis including NHS weight loss services, exercise, and diet strategies.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-25 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Weight management is one of the most impactful things you can do for your arthritis. Research shows that losing just **5% of your body weight** can significantly reduce joint pain, and every 1 pound lost removes **4 pounds of pressure** from your knees.

Why Weight Matters for Arthritis

- Mechanical stress — excess weight directly increases pressure on weight-bearing joints (knees, hips, spine)
 - Inflammation — fat tissue (adipose) produces inflammatory chemicals (adipokines) that worsen arthritis throughout the body — including hands
 - Disease progression — being overweight accelerates cartilage breakdown
 - Treatment effectiveness — weight loss improves response to medications and physiotherapy
 - Surgical outcomes — maintaining a healthy weight improves outcomes from joint replacement surgery
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The Arthritis-Weight Challenge



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Losing weight with arthritis can feel like a catch-22: pain limits exercise, and reduced activity makes weight gain easier. But strategies exist:

Low-Impact Exercise Options

- Swimming/aqua aerobics — water supports 90% of body weight
- Cycling (stationary or outdoor) — minimal knee impact
- Walking — even 10-minute walks count
- Chair-based exercises — effective for those with severe mobility limitations
- Resistance bands — build muscle without heavy weights

Dietary Strategies

- Follow a Mediterranean diet — anti-inflammatory AND supports weight management
 - Focus on protein — maintains muscle mass during weight loss (1-1.2g per kg body weight)
 - Reduce ultra-processed foods — high in calories and pro-inflammatory
 - Control portions — use smaller plates and eat slowly
 - Stay hydrated — sometimes thirst is mistaken for hunger
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NHS Weight Loss Support

Several free NHS programmes can help:

- NHS Digital Weight Management Programme — free 12-week online programme for adults with BMI 30+ (or 27.5+ for certain ethnic groups)
 - NHS Better Health — free resources including the NHS Weight Loss Plan app
 - GP referral — your GP can refer you to local weight management services
 - Dietitian referral — ask your GP for a referral to an NHS dietitian for personalised advice
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Setting Realistic Goals



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- Aim for 0.5-1kg (1-2lbs) per week — slow, steady loss is sustainable
- Even 5-10% weight loss makes a meaningful difference to joints
- Focus on non-scale victories: less pain, more mobility, better sleep
- Don't compare yourself to others — your body and your arthritis are unique

Weight management alongside arthritis is challenging but achievable. Ask your GP about NHS support services — you don't have to do it alone.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis and weight management in the uk?

Short answer: Losing weight can significantly help arthritis by reducing pressure on joints and decreasing inflammation. Even a 5% body weight loss can ease joint pain and improve treatment effectiveness. Strategies include low-impact exercises like swimming or cycling and dietary changes such as a Mediterranean diet. The NHS offers free weight management programmes and GP referrals for support.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk